Ball tampering isn't black and white, because there are inconsistencies in interpretation. Though this is an area of current debate, you are not allowed to put an artificial substance on the ball, but you are permitted to spit on it, to assist the shine. You must not pick at the seam, but the ball cannot surely be said to be in a natural state if you are polishing one side of it.

That's legal, but when you put sugar on the surface, by eating a sweet and applying impregnated spit to the ball, that's a no-no. It certainly makes the ball shinier, but does it make it swing abnormally? The jury is out, though technically you are not allowed to take sweets on to the field. The residue from energy drinks, taken in the break? That's also in the grey area.

It can get a little silly. Faf du Plessis, South Africa's captain, was fined his entire match fee in a Test at Hobart in November 2016 for ball tampering when he was spotted on TV with a mint under his tongue. The Australian media pursued him like a convicted criminal in the build-up to the following Test, where I suspect I was not the only player silently hailing the strength of character that resulted in him scoring a century.

As he explained afterwards: 'As a player, I was always taught when you're trying to get the ball to swing you've got to put something on the ball. So for me, that was a normal day at the office. I wasn't trying to do something different. My technique was bad: the sweet was out on my tongue, and the camera could see it. Obviously now I know that you can't be that obvious about it.'

I've eaten sweets and shined the ball without directly using sugary spit. Many players chew gum. There's something delightfully old-fashioned about the memory of the Aussies being upset when Marcus Trescothick was caught in possession of a Murray Mint in the 2005 Ashes. Australian teams of that vintage were hardly blushing innocents.

When I first faced them, in 2006, they played tough. A little like Stephen Hendry or Ronnie O'Sullivan in snooker, they occasionally won on reputation. I thought them fine; they chirped a bit, but never sought to bully me, as a new kid on the block. I won four out of seven series against them; we usually gave as good as we got. It was almost a badge of honour when Brad Haddin called us bad winners.

Of course, they sledged when they got on top of you. That's fine, providing it doesn't degenerate into personal abuse. That doesn't happen too often, though I once had a ding-dong with South African wicketkeeper